

Interview Finding	Broader Business English Issue
Developers freeze or over-escalate when disagreeing with authority	Directness calibration. Learners either over-hedge and lose their point, or over-assert and damage the relationship
Technical professionals cannot explain their own work in plain language	Expert blind spot. Fluency in domain language does not transfer to plain language communication
High performers freeze in formal settings like interviews and stand-ups	High-competence, low-performance under social pressure. A documented pattern in professional English contexts
Conflict is avoided until it explodes	Indirect communication styles and face-saving behaviour creating delayed and responses
Writing is vague, informal, or structured poorly	Absence of professional writing frameworks. Not a grammar problem but a format and tone problem
Senior professionals struggle to present themselves at their level	Register mismatch. Capable practitioners using casual or hedging language in high-stakes contexts, undermining credibility

This cross-referencing serves two purposes. First, it validates that the course content will be relevant beyond the five people interviewed. Second, it ensures the training addresses root causes rather than surface symptoms.

5. Gap Analysis

Current State	Target State	Gap	Typical Business English Issue
Can write work emails but tone is often too stiff or too informal	Writes emails that match the situation, clear, professional, right register	Register control, email conventions, hedging language	Learners default to either overly formal written structures borrowed from academic English or casual conversational tone. Neither suits professional correspondence
Goes quiet in meetings, understands but does not contribute	Speaks up, asks questions, and gives input in group settings	Speaking confidence, meeting phrases, turn-taking	Passive participation in group settings is one of the most documented patterns in Business English, learners understand far more than they produce, particularly when native or fluent

			speakers dominate the room
Understands clear slow speech but struggles on calls	Follows fast or accented speech and responds in real time	Listening strategies, exposure to varied accents	Formal English instruction exposes learners to slow, neutral speech. Real workplace calls involve reduced speech, overlapping talk, and regional accents that learners have rarely trained for
Knows grammar rules but thinks in first language and then translates	Produces spoken English without mental translation delay	Fluency, automaticity, thinking directly in English	Rule-based English education produces accurate but slow speakers, automaticity requires high-volume low-stakes output practice that most formal instruction does not provide
Can explain technical work to teammates	Can explain technical work to non-technical clients, managers, or executives	Plain language, audience awareness, simplification	Audience-awareness is a known gap in professional English, learners adjust vocabulary for proficiency level but rarely adjust structure, depth, or framing for a non-specialist listener
Freezes when asked an unexpected question	Buys time, thinks out loud, and responds clearly under pressure	Stalling phrases, confidence under pressure, real-time repair	High-competence learners frequently underperform in unscripted spoken situations. The absence of stalling and repair strategies makes them appear less capable than they are
Pushes back aggressively or goes silent when disagreeing	Voices disagreement clearly, respectfully, and with reasoning	Diplomatic language, framing risk, assertive communication	Directness calibration is one of the most cross-cultural Business English challenges. Learners either over-hedge until their point disappears or assert too bluntly, both of which damage professional relationships
Cannot explain their own process or decisions clearly	Speaks confidently about their own work, value, and decisions	Self-presentation, professional storytelling, interview language	Professional self-presentation is rarely taught explicitly. Learners can do the work but lack the narrative structures to describe it credibly to an unfamiliar audience
Avoids difficult conversations, conflict, feedback, escalation	Handles professional conflict with directness and structure	Conflict language, feedback frameworks, escalation phrases	Avoidance of high-stakes interpersonal communication is well documented across Business English contexts. Learners lack both the language and the structural frameworks to initiate or navigate these conversations professionally